From Desolation to Da’at: The Haftarah of Tisha B’Av Morning as Prophetic Diagnosis and the Only Ground of Glory

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Introduction

On the morning of Tisha B’Av the congregation sits low upon the floor. After the Torah reading of Devarim 4:25–40—the solemn warning of exile that follows idolatry and the conditional promise that seeking with all one’s heart and soul will find—the Haftarah is chanted in the broken melody of Eikhah: Yirmiyahu 8:13–9:23. This selection forms the third of the three Haftarot of Admonition read during the Three Weeks, following the earlier portions from Jeremiah 1 and Jeremiah 2. Together they construct a progressive movement from the call of the prophet, through the diagnosis of national failure, to the deepest expression of grief and the possibility of return.

The portion moves from the total withering of the covenantal vine, through the prophet’s fountain of tears and the diagnosis of a society whose speech has become a weapon of systematic deceit, to the climactic declaration that the only legitimate human glory is the understanding and knowledge of the G-d who practices ḥesed, mishpat, and tzedakah on the earth.

This essay examines the text in its literary and theological integrity. It surveys classical meforshim, Chassidic and modern Orthodox readings, engages academic biblical scholarship, and places the prophetic diagnosis in sustained conversation with republican political theory. The central claim is that the forsaking of Torah and the corrosion of public trust by deceit destroy the conditions of ordered communal and political life, while *daʿat Hashem*—knowledge of the G-d whose delight is in the public practice of the divine attributes—supplies both the redemptive horizon of Torah thought and the transcendent foundation required for any durable reconstruction of non-dominating order.

I. Textual Architecture: From Withered Vine to the Only Glory

The portion opens with a decree of absolute consumption:

“אָסֹף אֲסִיפֵם נְאֻם־ה' — I will utterly consume them, says the Lord. There shall be no grapes on the vine, nor figs on the fig tree; even the leaves will be withered, for what I gave them they transgressed.” (8:13)

The doubled verb *asof asifem* signals total annihilation, an expression of destruction paralleled in Zephaniah 1:2. The vine and the fig tree are the classic symbols of settled covenantal fruitfulness in the Land (cf. Micah 4:4; 1 Kings 5:5). Their withering is not merely agricultural failure but the withdrawal of the blessing that had accompanied fidelity to the statutes given at Sinai. Rashi notes that the leaves wither because the people transgressed the commandments that had been given to them.

The people respond with the language of siege and poisoned water: they gather into fortified cities only to sit in silence, having hoped for peace and received terror (8:14–15). From Dan the snorting of horses is already heard; the whole land trembles at the sound of the neighing of the stallions (8:16). Serpents that cannot be charmed are sent (8:17). The imagery shifts from agricultural to military and zoological, underscoring the comprehensive nature of the judgment.

The prophet's own heart falters under the vision: "Were I to suppress my grief, my heart is sick within me" (8:18). The cry of the daughter of the people rises from a distant land: "Is the Lord not in Zion? Is her King not in her? Why have they provoked Me with their graven images and with foreign vanities?" (8:19). The harvest is past, the summer ended, and they are not saved (8:20). The prophet identifies completely with the people's wound: "For the wound of the daughter of my people I am wounded; I mourn, dismay has taken hold of me" (8:21).

Then comes the verse that has entered the liturgical bloodstream of Jewish mourning:

"הֲצָרִי אֵין בְּגִלְעָד אִם־רֹפֵא אֵין שָׁם — Is there no balm in Gilead? Is there no physician there? Why then has the health of the daughter of my people not been restored?" (8:22)

Rashi's reading remains decisive and profound: of course there is balm in Gilead (cf. Jeremiah 46:11); the real absence is of *tzaddikim*—righteous teachers and models—from whom the people might have learned to mend their ways. The failure is not medical or botanical but moral and spiritual. The prophet therefore wishes that his head were waters and his eyes a fountain of tears, that he might weep day and night for the slain of the daughter of his people (8:23).

Chapter 9 intensifies the social diagnosis. The prophet longs for a desert lodging so that he might leave a people of adulterers and traitors whose tongues are drawn like bows of falsehood, who proceed from evil to evil and do not know Hashem (9:1–2). Trust has collapsed at the most basic level: "Let each one beware of his neighbor and do not trust any brother, for every brother is a complete deceiver (*akov yaakov*) and every neighbor goes about with slanders" (9:3). They have taught their tongue to speak lies until they are wearied by the labor of iniquity (9:4–5). "Your habitation is in the midst of deceit; through deceit they refuse to know Me, says the Lord" (9:5). The refusal to know G-d and the culture of systematic falsehood are two sides of the same coin.

The Lord will refine and test them (9:6). The tongue is a deadly arrow that speaks peace while laying traps in the heart (9:7–8). Shall He not punish such a nation (9:8)?

The land itself is ruined. Mountains and wilderness dwellings wither; the lowing of cattle is not heard; birds and beasts have fled (9:9). Jerusalem becomes heaps, a lair of jackals; the cities of Judah a desolation without inhabitant (9:10). The question is posed with rhetorical force: "Who is the man so wise that he can understand this? And who is he to whom the mouth of the Lord has spoken, that he may declare it? Why is the land ruined and withered like a wilderness, without anyone passing through?" (9:11). The answer is given without ambiguity:

"Because they have forsaken My Torah which I set before them, and have not hearkened to My voice nor walked in it. But they have followed the stubbornness of their heart and after the Baalim which their fathers taught them." (9:12–13)

The forsaking of Torah is not an abstract theological error; it produces a society in which language itself becomes a weapon, in which the ordinary bonds of loyalty and truth dissolve, and in which the Land—the concrete arena of covenantal life—can no longer sustain human habitation. Exile, the sword, and the uncollected corpses that fall "like dung upon the open field… with none to gather them" follow (9:14–21). Professional mourning women are summoned; the dirge must be taught to the next generation because death has entered the windows and the palaces.

Then the reversal that constitutes the theological and political heart of the portion:

"Thus says the Lord: Let not the wise man glory in his wisdom, nor the mighty man glory in his might, nor the rich man glory in his riches. But let him who glories glory in this: that he understands and knows Me, that I am the Lord who practices kindness, justice, and righteousness on the earth; for in these things I delight, says the Lord." (9:22–23)

Rashi's gloss is precise: only when wisdom includes the understanding and knowledge of Hashem does it become something in which one may legitimately glory. The three capacities that ordinarily secure status—intellectual mastery, physical or military power, and material wealth—are relativized. What remains is *daʿat Hashem*, and that knowledge is not merely cognitive. To know the G-d who *practices* ḥesed, mishpat, and tzedakah is to be drawn into the imitation of those same attributes. The divine delight is not in abstract theological correctness but in the concrete enactment of covenantal ethics upon the earth.

II. Classical Commentaries in Depth

Classical meforshim read the portion as both historical prophecy of the Babylonian destruction under Nebuchadnezzar and perennial diagnosis of covenantal failure. Rashi consistently ties the imagery of withering and the absence of balm to the people's refusal to learn from the righteous and their transgression of the given statutes. On 8:13 he emphasizes the completeness of the destruction. On 8:22 he pivots the question from physical medicine to spiritual leadership. On 9:22–23 he insists that wisdom without knowledge of G-d is not true wisdom.

Abarbanel, with his characteristic political acuity, reads the prophetic office itself as a check on power. The collapse of trust (9:3–5) and the rise of private glory (9:22) parallel the corruption of the polity that precedes exile. His broader oeuvre—anti-monarchical tendencies in certain readings, insistence on the limited character of kingship according to Deuteronomy 17, and the priority of divine law—supplies a natural bridge to later political readings of the Hebrew polity as a model of checked power under transcendent law.

Malbim emphasizes the calibrated character of the rebuke and the precise timing of the judgment. Radak and Ibn Ezra attend to the psychological and linguistic dimensions of the prophet's grief and the people's deceit. The consensus of the classical tradition is that the root cause is the forsaking of Torah, the social expression is the culture of falsehood, and the only path of reconstruction is the recovery of knowledge of the G-d of the attributes.

III. Chassidic and Modern Orthodox Perspectives

In Chassidic thought, *hester panim* is not arbitrary abandonment but a concealment whose intensity forges greater capacity for revelation (*gilui*). The depth of hiddenness corresponds to the soul's and the nation's capacity for light. Jeremiah's tears and the final call to *daʿat* are read as the movement from calibrated concealment to the possibility of return. The Tanya's teachings

on *daʿat* as the unifying faculty that connects the mind to the heart, and the Rebbe's teachings on *hester panim* as profound love that prepares vessels for greater light, illuminate the final verses as the core of true glory that survives the Churban.

Modern Orthodox voices deepen the same axis. Reflections on Tisha B'Av as the day of confrontation with divine judgment and the possibility of *teshuvah* resonate with the movement from fountain of tears to knowledge of the G-d of the attributes. National mourning is understood not as terminal but as the ground from which national rebirth becomes possible when the knowledge of Hashem is recovered and practiced in the concrete forms of kindness, justice, and righteousness.

IV. Academic Biblical Scholarship

Academic approaches range from historical-critical reconstructions of the late-monarchic and early-exilic context (Jeremiah's activity under Jehoiakim and Zedekiah, the Babylonian siege of 588–586 BCE) to literary readings that emphasize the carefully structured movement from agricultural and military desolation through social disintegration to theological climax. Some scholars highlight the prophetic critique of the temple cult and the monarchy; others stress the social dimension—the collapse of *fides*, the weaponization of language, the refusal of mutual knowledge that is the precondition of covenantal community.

Purely historical-critical readings risk reducing the text to a document of its time and emptying the redemptive horizon opened by the final verses. Overly harmonizing traditional readings may underplay the terror of the *hester* and the genuine agency of human corruption. The literary unity of the movement from withered vine to *daʿat* is the prophetic claim that the only way out of collapse is the recovery of the knowledge of the G-d whose attributes ground both personal virtue and public justice.

V. Republican Political Theory: Corruption, Non-Domination, and Transcendent Ground

Republican political thought supplies a powerful analytic language for the portion while itself requiring the theological foundation the portion supplies.

The culture of systematic deceit (9:3–5) is the classic republican nightmare: the corruption of public speech, the collapse of trust (*fides*), the replacement of the common good by private interest. When every brother is a deceiver and every neighbor a slanderer, the conditions of non-domination (in the sense developed by Philip Pettit) and of ordered liberty (in the neo-Roman tradition recovered by Quentin Skinner) are destroyed. The glorying in private wisdom, might, and riches (9:22) is precisely the elevation of private excellence over the common good that classical and early-modern republicans diagnosed as the death of the republic.

Daniel J. Elazar's covenantal federalism and Eric Nelson's recovery of the "Hebrew Republic" in early-modern political thought show that the biblical polity itself—Sinai as consent-based compact, limited kingship (Deuteronomy 17), prophetic checks, deliberative institutions such as the Sanhedrin—was read by Christian Hebraists and later thinkers as a model of republican liberty under transcendent law. Abarbanel's political reading of the prophets belongs to this continuum.

Secular republicanism faces a perennial difficulty: what sustains civic virtue and the knowledge of the common good once the private goods of wisdom, power, and wealth become the objects of glory? The Haftarah answers with radical clarity. The only legitimate glory is the understanding and knowledge of the G-d who *practices* ḥesed, mishpat, and tzedakah. These attributes are not private virtues; they are the public, covenantal, and ultimately divine ground of a polity that refuses domination. *Daʿat Hashem* is therefore both the theological claim and the republican educational and ethical requirement. Without it, non-domination collapses into either domination by the strong or the endless procedural management of competing private interests.

VI. Synthesis and Implications

The Haftarah moves from total desolation to the sole remaining ground of glory. Classical readings correctly identify the forsaking of Torah and the absence of *tzaddikim* as the root. Academic readings correctly diagnose the social and political dimensions of the collapse. Republican theory correctly names the corruption of trust and the elevation of private glory as the death of ordered liberty. Torah theology correctly insists that only *daʿat Hashem*—knowledge of the G-d who practices the attributes that ground justice and kindness—can reopen the path.

Without the theological claim, republicanism lacks a durable ontological ground for non-domination. Without the political and social diagnosis, theology risks quietism or purely private piety. Without the classical insistence on Torah as the constitutive order, both risk becoming abstract. The full reading holds the tension: the Churban is real; the tears are required; the only glory that survives and rebuilds is the understanding and knowledge of the G-d whose delight is in the public practice of ḥesed, mishpat, and tzedakah.

On Tisha B'Av the text is not merely commemorated; it is performed. The congregation sits low, the voice breaks, the tears are real. Yet the final verses open a path that does not depend on the restoration of the Temple or the integrity of the Land. The knowledge of the G-d of the attributes can be acquired, practiced, and transmitted even in exile and mourning. That knowledge remains the seed of any future reconstruction.

May the One who practices kindness, justice, and righteousness on the earth yet delight in those who seek Him, and may the day of darkness become, in the fullness of time, a day of light.

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